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A Family Military Tradition

Three generations of my family – from 1914 to 2007 – have served in the great Indian Army, making it almost a century of family military tradition in the service of the nation. And rising from the 'ranks' to a four-star general in this period has been a unique achievement for us.

Our family roots take us back to the Aryans, or so was the conviction of my great-grandparents. I would like to believe this even if it is a myth! There appears to be a difference of opinion about the advent of the Aryans (between 2000 BC and 1500 BC) in the Indus Valley, the plains of Punjab and beyond up to the Indo-Gangetic region. Marwaha (Merwaha), our clan, is believed to have come to the Punjab from Merv or Marusthal, and claims to have its origins in Central Asia. They are said to have entered southwest Punjab through the Bolan Pass, and their earliest traceable settlement was at Goindwal, near Amritsar (Sketch 1.1). They belonged to the Khatri Sarin group and were descendants of Bhai Balu of Goindwal, who was appointed by the third guru of the Sikhs, Guru Amar Das, and whose shrine is at Dadan, near Ludhiana.[1]

My grandfather, Sepoy Atma Singh, was a burly Sikh. A fair-complexioned man, his rosy cheeks used to turn ruddier under the summer sun. He was a simple, down-to-earth sipahi, a private in the army. An accomplished drummer, he was in the Pipes and Drums platoon of 1/67 Punjab Regiment (presently 1st Battalion, the Parachute Regiment). In the good old days, the 'pipers' were the traditional vanguard of the infantry battalions and led them into the battlefield. My grandpa's pay was a meagre seventeen rupees or